

THE FINAL ARBITER

Why the Pakistan Army is inseparable from the political destiny of a country at war with itself



CROSSED SWORDS: PAKISTAN, ITS ARMY AND THE WARS WITHIN
by SHUJA NAWAZ
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■ By Manvendra Singh

A book on the army by an insider is always a source of great enjoyment. Shuja Nawaz may not have actually worn the uniform, but he was as close as one could get to the Pakistan Army without serving in it, which has enabled him to serve up a wealth of information. Then there are some invaluable anecdotes and routine ripostes about a hesitant leadership and inadequacy of resources and instructions required to conduct a war. While in the Indian context, Nawaz refers to the political authority, in Pakistan it is the military—which is powerful enough to decide the fate of the citizenry—that he alludes to.

Crossed Swords is eminently readable and exciting at times. Born into a family that had produced only soldiers, and married into one equally devoted to the military way of life, Nawaz has inherited a legacy that allows him to shed light on little-known aspects of the army and its functioning. He hails from a family that has produced soldiers even before the invasion by Mahmud of Ghazni, when it converted to Islam. It was his elder brother, former chief of army staff General Asif, who suggested that he try his hand at some other profession. And Nawaz did, hopping from journalism to various appointments in multilateral organisations, until the tug of the army could not be resisted much longer. It was then that he decided to write the book.

There are essentially two books within *Crossed Swords*. The first draws on heritage and oral tradition and the second on documented research and scholarship. Local tales, family stories and historical fables—such as the encounter between Alexander of Macedon and Porus—

introduce the subject of military identity. This section of the book, however, could have been better edited since sentences and subjects tend to repeat themselves in several places.

Any discussion on the Pakistan Army—from the colonial British-Indian troops to the medievalist ogre that many claim the organisation has become in the 21st century—must invoke the question: the country for the army or the army for the country? Nawaz, observing from his vantage point, takes the reader on the road from the transfer of power to the army to its present-day authority, presenting vivid portraits of the Sandhurst-

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POWER OF THE BARREL: Pakistan Army



trained officer cadres, with their affected accents, and the more local strains of faith. The book also deals with the operational aspects of the military, right from the first Indo-Pak war over Kashmir in 1948 to the last tussle over Kargil in 1999. In between, the military ruled for many years, which account for a considerable part of Pakistan's history. Nawaz presents many details from the Ayub Khan era and clearly analyses where and why it began to go wrong.

A study on Pakistan has to focus on Kashmir, which is at the centre of thought in GHQ, Rawalpindi. So even as Kashmir and Kargil are amply

discussed, it is intriguing that there is no mention of the foreign minister-level talks between Swaran Singh and Zulfikar Ali Bhutto. It was the late Bhutto who had forced Pakistan into the 1965 war by manipulating the military mind. The military, in turn, subsequently manipulated the politicians. Other accounts wonder if Bhutto consulted Ayub before going ahead with the talks, but whatever the answer, it does not merit a mention in the many pages Nawaz devotes to Ayub's rule.

What is also missing—though not in entirety—is a study of the ISI as a product, not simply as a process. The

roots of the rot that pervades the military machine and the answer to what ails the Pakistani state and its army can be traced to the ISI and what it has become today. Unless corrective measures are taken, there is little hope that both institutions would be able to stand up to the rigours of the 21st-century world. Towards the end of the book, in 'Today and Tomorrow', Nawaz writes about changing the structures to handle the situation better. Some of the recipes are applicable to the Indian Army as well, but for entirely different reasons. And this only highlights the differences between the two nations. ■